

Mental Training

We climb with our mind—our hands and feet are merely an extension of our thoughts and will.

The quickest way to enhance your performance in almost anything is to improve the quality of your thinking. This is definitely true in climbing, whether you're working a highball boulder problem, sport route, multipitch traditional line, or alpine route. All performance operates from the inside out—your beliefs, focus, fears, confidence, preparation, and problem-solving abilities form the foundation from which you will either succeed or fail.

Great performances begin with bulletproof confidence, singular focus, positive emotions, and a tough yet agile mind-set. Conversely, setbacks and failures often result from the worry, doubts, tension, and uncertainties that are born from a poorly harnessed mind running wild with fearful thoughts. It's my belief that whether you (or I) will succeed or fail on a climb is often predetermined in your subconscious (and perhaps even conscious) mind before you ever step off the ground.

While off-season strength training and year-round technique training are paramount for progressing into the higher grades, during the climbing season your biggest breakthroughs will come from toning and flexing your mental muscle. Toward this end, this chapter details two dozen powerful mental strategies and skills that will help elevate your performance and enjoyment.

Practice these skills with the same dedication and resolve as you would a new strength-training program, and you'll be pleasantly surprised with the results. Obtain the greatest payoff by applying these

skills every day, not just when you feel like it. For some, an almost instant breakthrough will follow on the rock, while others will need to persist and let these mental skills build to a critical value before they will produce a noticeable impact on climbing. (This depends upon the current degree of tone or atrophy of your mental muscle.)

Recognize that all these mental-training skills are interlaced and can produce a powerful synergy when all are put in practice. In aggregate they may produce an effect similar to unloading a ten-pound weight (or more!) from your back that you have unknowingly been hauling up climbs. I call this using your Mental Wings.

Mental Wings for Improving Performance

The late, great Wolfgang Güllich was fond of saying that “the brain is the most important muscle for climbing.” What makes this statement even more provocative is the fact that Güllich was one of the strongest people to ever pull down on stone. From the mid-1980s until his death in a car accident in 1992, he opened up several new grades of maximum difficulty by leveraging the synergy of his physical and mental fortitude. I support Wolfie's sentiment not only because the mind is one-third of the climbing performance triad (see figure 1.1) but also due to the fact that poor mental control can instantly sabotage your physical and technical abilities.

Below are ten strategies that you can start using today in all aspects of your life. Apply them

faithfully with the knowledge that most truly successful men and women in this sport possess these skills.

1. Separate your self-image from your performance.

If you are reading this book, then climbing surely plays a major role in your life. However, if your self-image is tied too strongly or singularly to this role, it leads to an obsessive need to perform perfectly every time you touch the rock. The result is intense pressure, anxiety, and fear of failure—all of which will make performing your best difficult, if not impossible.

The fact is, you will perform best in a process-oriented frame of mind, where the outcome is accepted as unknown and allowed to unfold without anticipation. Detaching your self-image from your climbing performance is the first step to escaping an outcome-oriented mind-set. Strive to focus only on things immediate to the act of climbing—your warm-up, mental rehearsal, gear selection; when climbing, focus only on the move and sequence at hand, never projecting ahead. Accept the feedback the route gives you without frustration or judgment, and liberate yourself to try new things, take chances, and—most important—fall. Such process orientation and self-image detachment will reduce pressure and anxiety; paradoxically, you'll climb better by not needing to!

2. Surround yourself with positive people.

There is an aura of influence that surrounds each of us, and its effects are based on our personality and attitude toward life and its events. Your thoughts and actions will affect the thoughts and actions of those around you, and vice versa. As I see it, there are three options—either climb alone, climb with upbeat and positive people, or climb with cynical and negative people. But why would you ever want to climb with the negative, excuse-making complainers of the climbing world? Their negative

aura will adversely impact your climbing and enjoyment whether you recognize it or not. The bottom line: Vow to either climb with positive individuals or climb solo. Both approaches can be hugely rewarding.

3. Stretch your comfort zone.

To improve in anything, your goals must exceed your current grasp and you must be willing to push beyond your comfort zone in your reach. In performing on the vertical plane, this means climbing onward despite mental and physical discomfort; it means challenging your fears head-on by doing what you fear; and it means attempting what looks impossible to you based on past experience. Through this process you will stretch your abilities to a new level, redefine your belief system, and reshape your personal vision of what is possible.

4. Anticipate and proactively manage your risk.

Climbing is an activity with obvious inherent risks, and the desire to climb harder often requires taking on even more. This can come in the form of obvious physical danger such as a potentially injurious fall, or as less tangible mental risk like opening yourself up to failure, criticism, and embarrassment. It's interesting to note that for some climbers, the physical danger can feel more tolerable than the mental. As an example, consider a climber who foolishly continues upward on a horrendously dangerous route he's not prepared for because of the fear of being dissed (by those standing safely on the ground!) should he back off.

Make it your MO to carefully assess all the possible risks before starting up every climb. Determine ways that you can reduce the risk of the climb (such as rigging a belay differently than usual or getting an extra spotter or crash pad), and anticipate how you will respond to new emerging risks as you climb (for instance, discovering there are no protection placements higher up the route). As for the



Chelsea Rude is focused and in the zone on Dolce Vita (5.13c), Ceuse, France. MATTY HONG

mental risks you might face (like the fear of failure), see the first mental strategy on separating your self-image from your performance.

5. Fortify your confidence.

Your degree of self-confidence is primarily based on your self-image and the thoughts you possess minute by minute and day by day. For example, pondering past failures, allowing free rein to demeaning self-talk, or dwelling on the chance of falling will deflate self-confidence and sow the seeds of failure.

Conversely, peak performers consciously narrow their thoughts and focus onto things that will

fortify and build confidence. You, too, can do this as you prepare for an ascent, by taking a mental inventory of past successes, reviewing and believing in your skills and strengths, and acknowledging your preparation and investment in training. Do all this and you will grow more energized and confident as you engage the rock, and most likely climb your very best.

6. Use visualization to foster a peak performance zone.

“The zone” is that state where everything comes together for a perfect ascent that seems almost effortless and automatic. The trick is being able to

create this state on demand, despite stressful conditions such as the heat of competition or before a hard redpoint attempt. Here's how.

First, use visualization to reenact the positive feelings of a good performance in a past similar situation. Create about a sixty-second mental movie of this past event using all your senses. Make the pictures crisp and bright, and let the emotion and feeling of the success take over your body. With the positive, confident emotions of this past event now internalized for use in the present, you can begin mental rehearsal of the upcoming climb. Begin by visualizing yourself climbing the route from a detached on-TV perspective—it's in this mode of visualization that you'll develop a sequence and strategy for the ascent. Next, close your eyes and climb the route in your mind's eye—feel the moves play out successfully to create a mental blueprint for action (you'll find more detailed instruction on visualization later in this chapter). Now open your eyes and take on the route for real, one move at a time.

7. Use preclimb rituals to create an ideal performance state.

The things you think and do in the minutes and moments before you climb form the foundation onto which your performance is built. A shaky foundation generally leads to a shaky performance; a solid foundation usually gives birth to a solid performance. The nature of your foundation (sand or stone?) is influenced by the quality of your preclimb rituals. These are things you do to best prepare for the ascent, including scoping the route, visualizing the sequence, preparing your gear, warming up, and even your way of putting on your shoes. Everything down to tiny details, such as breathing rate, posture, and final thoughts, should be programmed into the rituals that lead up to the moment you step onto the rock.

Develop your rituals based on past experience. What things did you think or do before some of your best ascents in the past? What did you eat or drink, how did you warm up, and how long

did you rest between climbs? Awareness of all the things (little and big) that led up to your best performances is key to being able to reproduce similar results in the future. Once your rituals become tried and true, stick to them!

8. Control stress and tension before they control you.

This strategy is central to climbing your best, because tension kills performance. Period. Tension is often a physical manifestation of mental stress, although it can also develop in overstressed muscles or as the result of an inadequate warm-up. Either way, the outcome is the same—poor motor control (inefficient movement), unproductive emotions, and quite often failure. Here are two ways to control tension and stress on the fly. First, direct your thinking away from pressure-producing thoughts and focus only on the process of climbing. Engage the route completely and stay in the moment. Second, use rest positions to break from the process of climbing and direct your thoughts inward for a tension check. Use the six-step ANSWER Sequence (see page 43) to clear tension and return to center in less than one minute—perfect for use at every mid-route rest position.

9. Engage in positive self-talk.

Inside our heads, each of us has a “critic” voice and a “doer” voice that gab throughout our waking hours. While the critic voice can be useful in a few situations (such as evaluating weaknesses or performance errors), it's the doer voice that compels action, keeps us positive, and, in fact, helps us perform effectively. Controlling this internal self-talk is fundamental to controlling our attitude and climbing our best.

Which voice—the critic or the doer—rules your mind? Hopefully you'll conclude that the doer's voice rules your mental roost about 95 percent of the time (or more). If not, you can surely improve your performance by eliminating any

self-destructive internal dialogue. The first step is to sever your ties to negative, critical people: Their verbal and nonverbal communication will absolutely pollute your thoughts and attitude.

Next, strive to heighten your awareness of your self-talk—the goal is to think about what you are thinking about!—and allow the doer voice to run the talk show. When you notice the critic voice speaking up, determine if it is useful (for instance, to help with risk management) or just trash talk. Take the critic's non-useful comments and invert them into positive statements. For example, change *This route looks impossible* to *This route looks challenging*; replace *I feel nervous* with *I feel energized*; convert *I'll probably fall* into *I think I can do this, but if I fall it's okay because I'll get it next time*. Direct such positive self-talk on every climb and throughout every day and you will marshal psychic energy that enhances your performance in all you do.

10. Love climbing, no matter what.

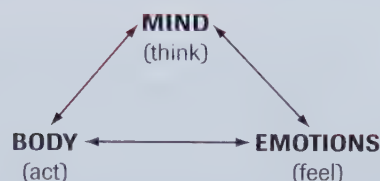
A common trait of successful people is resilience to criticism and bad results, and an unwavering belief that success will come with time and effort. Developing such a mind-set takes a disciplined effort to constantly spin negative feedback into some kind of a positive—real winners never dwell on the setbacks or accept defeat.

Remember, climbing is about the journey, not the summit. Vow to love the process of climbing and all it entails, whether it is a perfect send or a painful struggle. Sure, a perfect ascent is immensely gratifying; however, it's on the arduous journey that you actually become a better climber and grow as a person. The bottom line: Love climbing unconditionally and you will always have a great day on the rocks!

Controlling Your Emotions

Your emotions have a direct effect on your body and mind. What you are feeling exerts an influence over the quality of your actions and your ways of

Figure 3.1 How Emotions Run the Show



What you feel exerts an influence over how you think and what you do. Likewise, ways of thinking and acting affect how you feel.

thinking (see figure 3.1). Consider how nervousness before a climb can derail your concentration as well as trigger preclimb jitters throughout your body. We can then conclude that emotional control is essential for optimal performance.

Observe great climbers such as Chris Sharma and Alex Megos at work and you will notice either positive, productive emotions or no emotion at all. Even when they fall, you sense little anger or angst—only love of the process of climbing, which occasionally includes falling. Now consider how your thoughts and emotions evolve when the going gets tough—do you sometimes become negative, fearful, or even self-defeating? If so, then your physical performance will absolutely suffer given the intimate mind-emotion-body relationship shown in figure 3.1.

The following storyline illustrates how negative emotions can sabotage performance.

1. The climber leaves the ground and moves cautiously through the initial moves. He looks apprehensive, as if he's trying not to make any mistakes.
2. As he enters more difficult moves, his breathing becomes shallow and irregular.
3. Negative emotional energy rises, resulting in increased muscular tension and mental stress.
4. This building stress disrupts his coordination, balance, and footwork. Movements become

- tight, mechanical, and inefficient. He begins to overgrip holds.
5. He begins to hold back on hard moves, afraid to fully commit, and hangs out too long on marginal rests.
 6. The fight-or-flight syndrome is triggered, adding some adrenaline to the mix. This burst of energy may help the climber thrash through a few more moves; more commonly, however, the jolt causes him to grab the rope or a quickdraw and retreat from the route.
 7. The death grip sets in and muscles flame out.
 8. He falls and lets loose a few expletives.
 9. Hanging on the rope, he engages in critical thinking that further raises the tide of negative emotions.

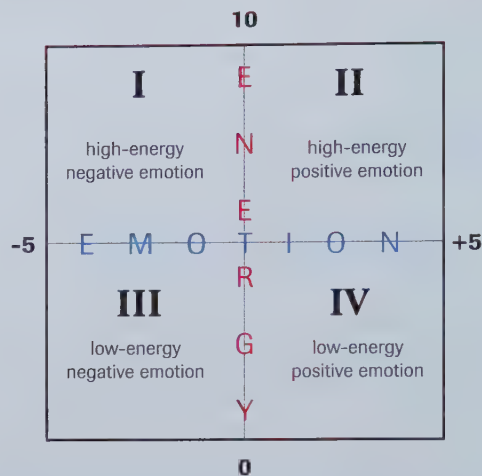
Does any part of this story sound familiar? If so, I have some good news. You can learn to rein in your emotions and thus open up a whole new level of climbing performance and enjoyment. If you have good emotional control already, I bet you can still improve your climbing by modulating your arousal level. Let's explore this murky subject of emotions and discuss how you can make some immediate positive changes.

Evaluating Your Emotional State

In evaluating your emotional state, the goal is to become aware of the "sign" of your emotions—positive or negative—and the magnitude of your arousal, high or low. Obviously, positive emotions have different effects on the mind and body than negative emotions. Similarly, the intensity of these emotions (the arousal level) plays a role in how you think and feel. To better understand this relationship, consider the Energy–Emotion Matrix (see figure 3.2).

The Energy–Emotion Matrix has four quadrants: high energy, positive emotion (upper right); low energy, positive emotion (lower right); high energy, negative emotion (upper left); and low energy, negative emotion (lower left). The matrix

Figure 3.2 The Energy–Emotion Matrix



What quadrant of the matrix are you most often in?

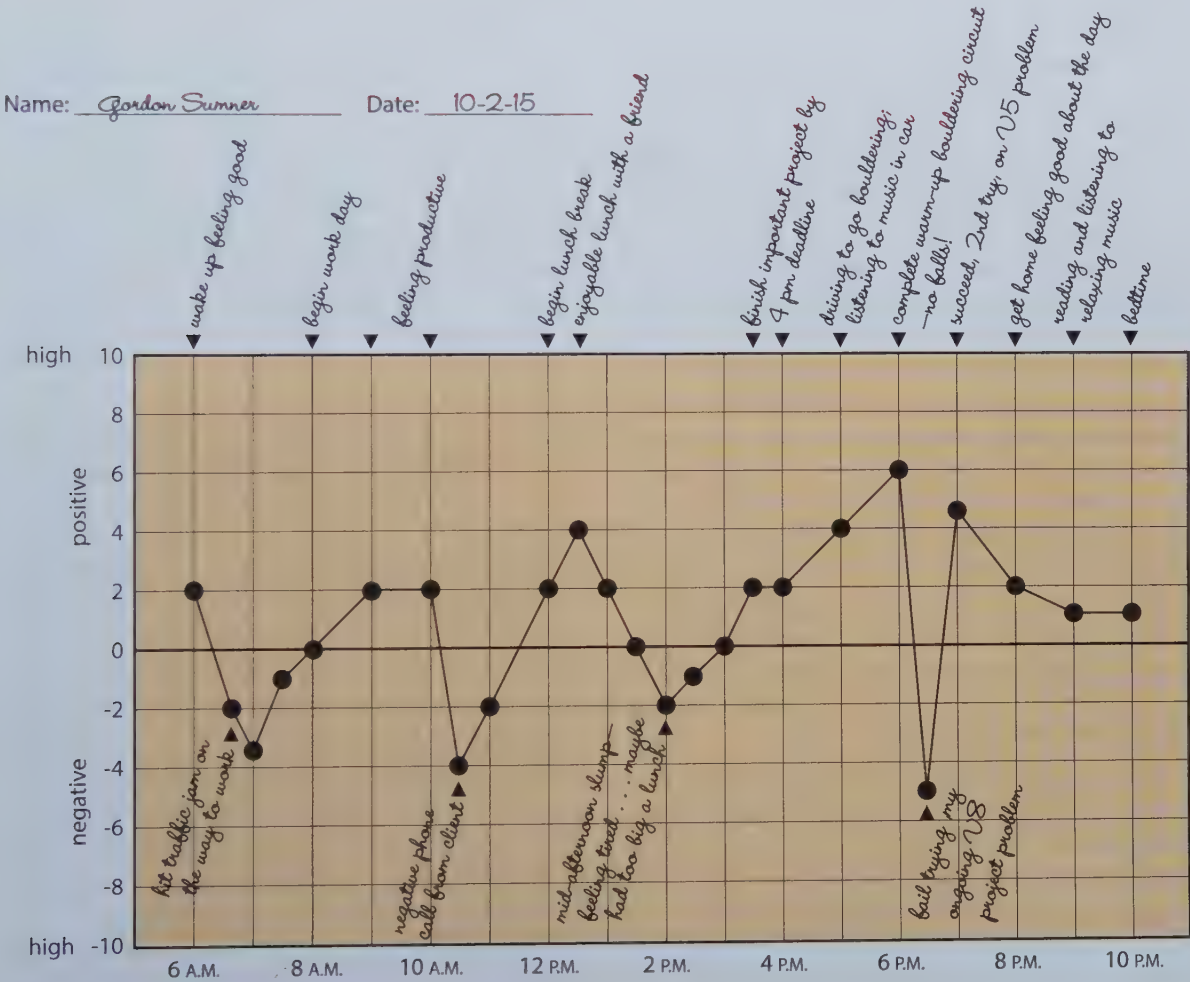
represents a continuum of emotion and energy across these four quadrants. Therefore, you can evaluate your present location in the matrix by grading your current energy level on a scale from 0 to 10 (low to high) and scoring your current emotional state on a scale from –5 (extremely negative) to +5 (extremely positive). Knowing where you are in the matrix and having the ability to change this location if it's not optimal in the current situation is fundamental to becoming a peak performer in any endeavor.

Obviously, your energy level and emotions fluctuate throughout the day and over the course of a climb, so your place in the matrix changes hour by hour and, maybe, minute to minute in extreme situations. I believe it's valuable to study your place in the matrix in everyday, nonclimbing situations, since your most common daily state will heavily determine your disposition when climbing (it's unlikely you can be a negative person at home and work, then become completely positive when you go climbing). Use the blank energy–emotion time

line contained in appendix B to plot your changing energy–emotional state throughout the day, as shown in figure 3.3. Begin upon waking in the morning, and score your state every thirty minutes, or when some event causes your emotion or energy to change in an instant.

After evaluating your energy–emotional state for a few days, see if you can identify any patterns. What time(s) of the day is your energy high or low? What events seem to trigger you becoming more positive or negative? Recognizing these patterns (and effects) empowers you to make modifications,

Figure 3.3 Sample Chart of Energy–Emotion Levels



Sample chart of energy–emotion levels throughout the day, including notes of triggers or events that effected an energy–emotion change.

such as striving to avoid negative triggers. Likewise, you may be able to see what charges up your energy level (and when) and what type of things make it tank. If you can't avoid negative triggers, it's vital that you know how to turn your state around. Below we'll discuss ways to modify your emotional state.

It's also beneficial to track how your state changes over the course of a day at the crags, and especially during an attempt of a hard boulder problem or route. While you certainly can't write down your score while on a route, you can mentally score yourself by simply asking, What quadrant am I in?

Before you can change your state, you must first determine the optimal state for the present moment. Of course, beginning in a positive emotional state is always ideal, but the optimal magnitude of your arousal (energy level) will vary depending on the type of task you are involved in. For instance, a low-positive (Quadrant IV) state is ideal for taking a test or meeting with your boss, while a high-positive (Quadrant II) is best for working out at the gym or playing a high-intensity sport. In climbing, it's almost always best to be in the low-energy, positive-emotion quadrant—creative thinking, learning, and fine motor skills all demand a relaxed, positive state. The exception would be when psyching up for a vicious boulder problem or a short, powerful sport route. In these cases, a high-energy, positive state is ideal.

Changing Your Emotional State

You can rapidly change your emotional state by leveraging the known relationships among the mind, emotions, and body (see figure 3.1). Just as your emotions exert an influence over your mind and body, you can use your mind and body to influence your emotions. In negative people the process tends to be reactive and runs itself, whereas happy, productive people are skilled at using their mind and body to produce positive emotions. So if

you make it habit to carry your body in a positive way (good posture, head up, smiling) and think in a positive way (grateful for what you have, reliving only good memories, focusing on future goals), you will feel positive and, in fact, be a generally happy and successful person. This is one of the most powerful distinctions in this book—live it!

You should now have a good sense of the things you can do to shift into a more positive state. Physiologically, you can take on a more extended posture and crack a smile, you can jump up and down or do anything physical, you can pump your fist in the air and exclaim “Yeah!” All these physical things will effect a rapid change in your emotions—try it now! Mentally, you can replay great events or climbs from the past, think about all you've accomplished in your life, ponder your good health or your fortune to have been born in a first-world country (where you can actually engage in a luxury activity like climbing), or visualize the medium- and long-term goals that excite you.

Tips for Optimizing Your Emotions

1. Regularly tune into your thoughts and self-talk. Evaluate what you are hearing. What quadrant are you in?
2. Supplant negative thinking with positive, productive thoughts. Direct solution-oriented thinking and dwell on your goals.
3. Use your body to change your state. Roll your shoulders back, take a few deep belly breaths, crack a big smile and laugh.
4. Leverage your emotional resources by reviewing past successes. In your mind's eye, vividly relive past great climbs and other amazing life events—feel the positive emotions charge you up in the present moment.

Hopefully you now recognize that either your emotions are controlling you or you are in control of your emotions. Happy people and peak performers (in sports and life) are those who are able to control their emotions and adjust their arousal level on demand. In our frantic society, and when participating in a potentially high-stress sport such as climbing, these emotion-modulating skills are invaluable. Strive to monitor your position in the matrix throughout the day and optimize your state when needed, and you'll discover a new quality of climbing and living!

Dealing with Fear

As I stated in *How to Climb* 5.12, “the ‘no fear’ mentality is for buffoons, beer-guzzling frat boys, and couch potatoes.” In climbing, *reasonable fears* keep you alive long enough to realize your potential and to send a long lifetime’s worth of stellar routes. For example, fear of taking a groundfall compels you to seek good protection on the lead and to drag a rope in the first place.

It’s *unreasonable fears* that derail performance. Things such as fear of falling on a well-protected route, fear of physical discomfort, fear of failure, and fear of embarrassment must all be eliminated if you are to climb your best. There are also preclimb fears such as I might be too tall, or too short, or too weak to do the climb, which—left unchecked—give birth to reality.

Fear:

Finally, there are subconscious, preprogrammed fears that are the root of many of the “dumb things” that seem to just happen. Have you ever fallen after the crux when the route is in the bag? Or have you slipped off a large hold or botched a wired sequence even though you felt in control? It may be that such mistakes are the result of unchallenged inner fears, not lack of ability. The key is to deal with your fears head-on, and not to run from them. Use the following exercise to identify and analyze your common fears. As the fears reveal themselves, use logic and reason to specifically counter each. If no logical counter is evident, however, the fear may be reasonable and worth heeding.



IDENTIFY AND ANALYZE YOUR COMMON CLIMBING FEARS

Start by writing down recurrent fears that regularly hurt your performance. If you can’t think of any on the spot, go for a climb and pay special attention to every preclimb thought and while-you-climb concern. List your fears down the left column, and then write an assessment of each fear in the space to the right. Use logic and reason to counter each fear. Your fraudulent fears should be easy to counter. If you identify a fear that is real and useful (for saving your neck), however, then you want to write down what action you can take to mitigate the fear.

Dealing with fear is an ongoing process since our fears are always changing. Review each poor

Assessment:

performance and identify what fear(s) may have contributed to your difficulties. To help you with this analysis, here's a primer on four basic climbing fears: fear of falling, fear of pain, fear of failure, and fear of embarrassment.

Fear of Falling

Fear of falling is inherent to climbing. Interestingly enough, it's not really falling that we fear but not knowing what the fall will be like. This explains why your first fall on a route is the scariest, while subsequent falls are often much less stressful. Beginners probably need some hands-on proof that falls can be safe. The best way for a would-be leader to gain trust in the system is by taking some intentional falls. Find a steep climb with bomber protection, use a good rope (and double-check your knot and buckle) and belayer, and then take a few practice falls. Start off with two-foot falls and build up to about twelve-footers (with the gear just below your feet). A more experienced climber fearful of falling on an upcoming on-sight climb can counter the fear during the preclimb warm-up. The tactic here is to mentally replay some past inconsequential falls and to believe fully that falls on this climb will be no different (if that is indeed the case—some falls are obviously deadly, and only a fool would ignore that possibility).

Fear of Pain

When pushing your limits, fear of pain can become a critical weakness. It causes you to give up long before your body has reached its physical limitations. The pain of climbing a continuously strenuous route is akin to that of running a mile at full speed—it freaking hurts! Fortunately, the pain is brief, and perseverance pays big dividends. Decide to push yourself a bit further into the discomfort zone each time you're on a hard route. Soon your pain threshold will be redefined, as will your limits on the rock. Ultimately, you'll advance into the realm of an elite climber when you become comfortable with being uncomfortable.

Fear of Failure

This deep-seated fear is often instilled during childhood when almost every action is classified by our family, teachers, and friends as either a success or a failure. We've all had childhood situations where the fear of failure was so gripping that we became immobilized and time seemed to stop. Fortunately, adults generally don't react quite this intensely, but it's still common for us to imagine all the bad things that could possibly go wrong. Once triggered, these negative thoughts can snowball and, more often than not, bring meaningful action to a halt and, in the worst case, become a self-fulfilling prophecy.

In climbing, fear of failure causes you to hold back. As your attack on a route becomes less aggressive than required, you'll find yourself second-guessing sequences in the midst of doing them, your breathing will become shallow, and you'll begin to overgrip the rock. You may even fall prey to paralysis by analysis.

Eliminate fear of failure in one of three ways. First, focus on what is *probable* instead of what is *possible*. Sure, it's human nature to always consider the worst-case scenario, but this almost never comes to pass. Counter these thoughts by considering what is probable and realistic based on past experiences.

The second way to nix this fear is to focus all your attention on the process of climbing, instead of pondering the possible outcomes. Concentrate on the things immediate to your performance—precise foot placements, relaxing your grip, moving quickly onto the next rest position, and so on. Your limited supply of energy is too valuable to waste worrying about how high you will climb or the eventual results. As William Levinson points out in his book *The Way of Strategy*, "To succeed, we must not care if we fail."

Along this same line, you must adopt the attitude that *It's okay to fall* (assuming a safe fall) and that *Falling won't bother me. I'll just get back up and give it another go*. By willingly accepting this fate (if it

should even happen), you totally dissolve the fear of failure that handcuffs so many climbers. Therefore, by being okay with falling, it's less likely you will. This simple idea is one of the most powerful in this book.

Fear of Embarrassment

Finally, there is fear of embarrassment and being dissed. Get over this now or you'll never fully enjoy climbing, or reach your potential. Realize that occasional bad-performance days are inevitable. Instead of trying to avoid them, simply accept that they happen, analyze why they happened, then bury them. With this attitude you will be free to try chancy moves and risk an occasional mistake. In the long run you'll often look like a hero, but never like a zero. Surely this is better than embracing the critics and accepting mediocrity all the time.

Tips for Managing Fear

1. Analyze your fears to determine if they are real or imagined. Take action to mitigate the risk(s) associated with your legitimate fears.
2. Overcome imagined fears with reason—know that these phantom fears are bogus. Redirect your thinking in productive ways, and resolve to dismiss all other illusionary fears that might surface.
3. Focus on the process of climbing, and detach from the possible outcomes. Let the climb unfold one move at a time.
4. Predetermine that you will accept failure should it happen. Recognize that you are not defined by your successes or failures; however, you are defined by the way you react to success and failure.
5. For a more in-depth study of fear—and many more powerful strategies for overcoming fear—check out my book *Maximum Climbing: Mental Training for Peak Performance and Optimal Experience*.

Don't forget, your friends know how good a climber you are, and they won't think any worse of you because of a poor performance. Anyone else critical of you really doesn't matter. Work on improving your self-confidence, and don't let the criticisms of others invade your thoughts.

In the end, embrace the attitude that there are no failures, only results. The results might not be ideal, but they do in fact contain important clues for improvement—do not overlook these guideposts for future success! The bottom line: By challenging your fears and doubling your exposure to fearful situations, you will double your rate of improvement and learn to excel in the most difficult and stressful situations.

Relaxation Training and Centering

More than ever before, there are a multitude of things in our lives that can result in high levels of stress. Our jobs, relationships, possessions, even driving to the crag can trigger a stress response such as muscular tension or negative thoughts. Interestingly, it's not the events or things in our lives that actually cause the stress, but instead our reaction to them. Knowing this, you are empowered to control your reactions to everything you experience and, in turn, regulate the total amount of stress in your life.

Recognizing that an event or situation is causing you to become stressed is the first step toward controlling its effects. Foster an acute awareness of your tension levels by regularly asking yourself things like *How do I feel?* or *Are there any growing pockets of muscular tension?* Make such tension checks a regular part of your day. For instance, do a quick check of your tension and stress levels every hour, and especially before any type of event that requires an optimal physiological state (a big meeting or hard climb). Keep an eye out for telltale signs of building tension such as a clenched jaw, overgripping a pencil or the steering wheel, or tightness and burning in the muscles of your neck, shoulders, or back.

On the rock, tension reveals itself in overgripping of holds, nervously muscling through a crux move, or a general lack of fluid motion. Again, your goal is to recognize and tone down the tension when it begins; otherwise it will rapidly snowball and sabotage your performance. This, in fact, is a common cause of blowing a sequence you thought you had wired, or falling off a route that should be well within your ability. By killing your economy of movement, building tension and stress may very well kill your performance. And it's probably been happening for so long that you don't even recognize its negative effects on your climbing.

The antidote to tension is, of course, relaxation. Following are two highly effective relaxation strategies as well as a great on-the-rock centering sequence that I call the ANSWER. Experiment with all three, and try to incorporate their use throughout your daily activities. In a short time you will become a master of stress and find yourself feeling much more relaxed—and also climbing harder, thanks to an increase in apparent strength (a result of reduced tension in the antagonist muscles and elimination of overgripping).

Progressive Relaxation

In the early 1940s American physician Edmund Jacobson developed a technique known as progressive relaxation, because he felt that by fully relaxing the muscles, you would in turn relax the mind (Garfield 1984). He found that relaxation could be best learned by deliberately tensing and relaxing specific muscle groups (see the “Progressive Relaxation Sequence” exercise that follows). This process results in a sharpened awareness of tension levels in the different parts of your body, and the ability to release the tension on demand. In time, you will be able to discern even small increases in muscular tension and act to immediately eliminate the tension before there's any degradation in performance.



PROGRESSIVE RELAXATION SEQUENCE

Perform the following procedure at least once a day. I find it most useful during a midday break, as part of a long rest period at the crag, or the last thing before falling asleep. Initially, the process will take about fifteen minutes. With practice, you'll be able to move quickly through the sequence and reach a state of complete relaxation in less than five minutes. Concentrate on flexing only the muscle(s) specified in each step. This is an invaluable skill you will find very handy when using the differential relaxation and ANSWER Sequences that are discussed later.

1. Go to a quiet location and sit or lie in a comfortable position.
2. Close your eyes and take five deep belly breaths. Inhale slowly through your nose to a slow, silent count to five, and then gradually exhale through your mouth to a slow, silent eight-count.
3. Keeping your eyes closed and maintaining slow, relaxed breathing, tense the muscles in your right lower leg for five seconds. Feel the tension in your right foot and calf muscles, then let go and relax the muscles completely. Compare the difference in sensation between the tense and relaxed states. Repeat this process with the left lower leg. With both of your lower legs now relaxed, think, *My feet and lower legs feel warm and light.* You should now feel your lower legs enter a deep state of relaxation.
4. Next, perform the same sequence in the muscles of the upper leg (one leg at a time). Tense the muscles in your upper leg for five seconds, then relax them. After doing this with both legs, finish up by thinking, *My upper legs feel warm and light.* Feel all tension dissolve as your upper legs drop into deep relaxation.
5. Repeat this process in your hands and lower arms. Begin by tensing the muscles below your right elbow by making a tight fist for five

seconds, then relax these muscles completely. Repeat this with the left hand and forearm, and conclude with the thought, My hands and forearms feel warm and light.

6. Repeat this procedure on the muscles in the upper arm.
7. Next, shift the focus to the many muscles of the torso (including the chest, abdominal, back, and shoulder areas). Repeat the process exactly.
8. Conclude with the muscles of the face and neck.
9. You should now be in a deep state of relaxation (possibly you will have fallen asleep by now). Mentally scan yourself from head to toe for any isolated pockets of remaining tension—if you discover any, visualize the tension escaping the muscle like air from a balloon.
10. At this point you can open your eyes and return to work or climbing with a renewed sense of calm and focus. Or you can leverage this relaxed state by performing some mind programming—visualization of the process of reaching some goal or the act of climbing some project route.

Using Differential Relaxation to Enhance Performance

Differential relaxation is used in active situations where you wish to relax any muscle(s) not needed for the task at hand. I find this skill especially useful in regaining an optimal state while hanging out and chalking at rest positions on the rock. I scan for unnecessary muscular contractions or pockets of tension and, with a few deep belly breaths, visualize the tension draining from the muscle like air escaping from a balloon. Try this next time you go climbing.

Many climbers shortchange themselves and reduce their apparent strength because of undue tension in muscles not needed for upward motion or stability. Unwanted contraction of the antagonist muscles or over-contraction of the prime movers interferes with even the simplest movements and wastes a tremendous amount of energy. Observe how climbers who try too hard or get gripped

on a route become extremely rigid and mechanical, maybe even while moving through an easy sequence. Instead of using their muscles optimally, they're pitting one muscle against another, resulting in stress, fatigue, and premature failure. Conversely, the best climbers actively control undue tension (it's a mainly unconscious process in top climbers), move with grace and fluidity, and maximize economy of motion and energy use. As masters of differential relaxation, they can move smooth and fast like a Porsche but still get the high "miles-per-gallon" of a Honda.

Skill in differential relaxation comes with increased sensitivity to various degrees of relaxation and tension—something you will learn quickly through daily use. Practice by releasing tension in unused muscles while in the midst of common everyday activities like driving your car, sitting at your desk, working around home, or even lying down for a quick nap. Scan your body for pockets of tension or any contracting muscles that aren't critical for the task at hand. For me, it's typically tension in the shoulders, a clenched jaw (if I'm concentrating intensely), or unnecessary fidgeting by my feet.

On the rock, strive for acute awareness of rising tension so you can nip it in the bud before it results in a drop-off in performance. It's my practice to perform these "quality assurance checks" at all rest positions. Sometimes I recognize things like general tightness in my shoulders, unnecessary tension in my legs, or a little more contraction of my arm and forearm muscles than is needed to stick the grip or body position. Differential relaxation allows me to correct these problems almost instantly—although I find centering and the ANSWER Sequence to be beneficial in these situations as well.



THE ANSWER SEQUENCE

Perform the ANSWER Sequence before and during each climb and in everyday situations where

you need to control tension, anxiety, and focus. Initially this six-step procedure will take a few minutes to perform. With practice you'll be able to go through the sequence in about ten seconds—perfect for use at marginal rest positions where getting centered could make the difference between success and failure.

A—AWARENESS OF RISING TENSION, ANXIETY, OR NEGATIVE THOUGHTS.

Acute awareness of unfavorable mental and physical changes is fundamental to optimal performance. It takes a conscious effort to turn your thoughts away from the outer world toward your inner world. Peak performers habitually make these tension checks every few minutes, so they can nix any negative changes before they snowball out of control. Make this your goal.

N—NORMALIZE BREATHING.

In climbing, your breathing should be deep, relaxed, and regular. Unfortunately, many climbers breathe unevenly during hard sequences, thus creating tension and degrading performance. Your goal is to foster deep, even breathing throughout the climb. The exception is “holding your breath” (Valsalva Maneuver) to create core tension during a hard move—a frequent requisite in doing hard boulder problems or sport climbs.

S—SCAN FOR SPECIFIC AREAS OF MUSCULAR TENSION.

In this step you perform a tension check. Scan all your muscles in a quick sweep to locate pockets of tightness. Commonly tight areas are the forearms (are you overgripping?), shoulders, upper back, chest, abdominals, and calves. The best way to relax a specific muscle is to consciously contract that muscle for a few seconds, then relax it and visualize the tension draining from it like air from a balloon (the differential relaxation technique).

W—WAVE OF RELAXATION.

Upon completing the tension check above, take a single deep breath and feel a wave of relaxation wash from your head to your toes.

E—ERASE THOUGHTS OF PAST EVENTS (AND POSSIBLE FUTURE OUTCOMES) AND FOCUS ON THE PRESENT.

This step involves freeing your mind from the ball-and-chain of undesirable past events. There is no benefit to pondering the last failed attempt or the heinous sequence you just barely fought through. Let go of the past and do not ponder the future—thoughts of the past and future are enemies of excellence in the present. Refocus on and engage the present moment.

R—RESET POSTURE AND FLASH A SMILE.

It's amazing how much positive energy you can generate simply by resetting your posture and flashing a smile. This final step of the ANSWER Sequence will leave you in a peak performance state and ready to climb into the zone. Trust your skills, have fun, and let the outcome take care of itself.

Getting Centered

Centering is a simple, effective means of maintaining (or regaining) complete control of your mind and body as you head up a difficult climb or into competition. When you're centered, you feel balanced, relaxed, and confident. Conversely, being out of center is characterized by feelings of imbalance, tension, awkward movement, and sometimes even growing stress and anxiety. And since it takes just one botched move, one piece of gear to pop out, or one burst of adrenaline to knock you way out of center, it's essential that you are aware of this dynamic and able to respond quickly with countermeasures.

The ANSWER Sequence is a powerful means for returning yourself to center in just a few seconds. The sequence involves deliberately redirecting

Tips for Controlling Tension and Anxiety

- Practice progressive and differential relaxation to develop the ability to relax individual muscles on demand.
- Strive for constant awareness of growing tension and anxiety. Take a tension check at each rest on a climb and intermittently throughout the day.
- Target relaxation in antagonist muscles—this will improve your climbing economy and enhance flow and fluidity of movement.
- While you climb, employ the ANSWER Sequence at each rest position to regain your center and optimal performance state.

your thoughts inward for a moment (usually at a rest on a climb) to modulate your breathing, level of muscle tension, posture, and mental attitude. Make its use as regular and automatic as chalking up, and you'll find yourself climbing more efficiently and consistently.

Visualization Training

Let's start off with an example of visualization. Sit back, relax, and vividly imagine the following scene as if it were a movie playing out before your eyes.

You are attempting to redpoint a route you have worked on before. You have just successfully climbed to the rest position that precedes the route's crux sequence. You are relaxed, calm, and confident as you shake out and rechalk. You feel a cool breeze blow across your body, and it seems to enhance the light, centered feeling you already possess. You gently grip the starting hold of the sequence, a sharp, positive fingertip edge. With steady breathing, you flash a smile and continue climbing.

You match hands and pull the fingertip edge to your chest. You then high-step your right foot

onto a tiny, crescent-shaped flake. You've hit it just right—it feels bomber. You rock over that glued right foot, spot, and then grab a match-book side-pull edge with your right hand. You flag your left leg across and below your high right foot to shift your center of mass over the right foot. You then extend off the right foot with a smooth, steady motion. Your left hand reaches up to snag a two-finger pocket—it feels solid. You move your left foot up to a high smear on a small dish hold and, with relaxed breathing, take aim on the final lunge. Then, with your mind locked on to the next hold, you throw the lunge and easily latch on to the mini bucket hold that's been so elusive. You clip the anchors and feel the rush of having ticked this personal best route.

This sequence exemplifies a fundamental and important exercise used by all the world's top athletes. Although similar to the mental rehearsals performed by some climbers, visualization goes beyond the simple task of reviewing route sequences. As in the above example, visualization involves making and playing a detailed mental movie, one with touch, sound, color, and all the kinesthetic feel of doing the moves. These mental movies enhance your climbing by helping to hardwire sequences (moves, body positions, and "feel"), increasing memory, and fortifying confidence. For this reason, use of visualization is as important to your success as your use of climbing shoes and a chalk bag. Don't leave the ground without doing it!

Many studies have shown that the brain is not always capable of distinguishing between something that actually happened and something that was vividly imagined (Kubistantsky 1986). (Déjà vu is such an experience—you can't always recall if the clear mental image that just surfaced is an actual memory or simply something you've thought about or dreamed.) Therefore, repeated visualization can trick the mind into thinking you've been there and done that before. Think of these mental movies as a blueprint for future actions—with this perspective,

you should understand why visualization must be as detailed and accurate as possible. Any bad coding (wrong moves) or fuzzy detail (uncertain sequences) may lead to a botched sequence or fall when you climb the route for real.

Types of Visualization

There are two primary modes of visualization: disassociated and associated. Disassociated visualization provides an “on-TV” perspective, where you see yourself climbing from an observer’s point of view. This mode of visualization is best for reviewing some past poor performance that you hope to improve upon. As a detached observer, you can replay the movie and objectively view the mistakes or falls without reliving the possibly unhappy emotions of the situation.

Associated visualization provides a “through-your-own-eyes” perspective and thus triggers small neurological reactions as if you were doing the climb, as well as the feel and emotion of the movie you are playing. This makes associated visualization ideal for preprogramming some future ascent. As discussed above, repeated playing of a highly detailed, positive mental movie helps trick the subconscious mind into thinking you’ve done the climb before. Just make sure you are using the associated, not disassociated, perspective when visualizing some future event.

DISASSOCIATED VISUALIZATION

If you are new to the practice of visualization, I suggest you begin with a simple, nonclimbing example. Go to a quiet location, sit or lie down comfortably, and relax. Using an observer’s point of view (disassociated), play a mental movie of the following scene as it might appear in your apartment or home.

Visualize yourself sitting on the couch and watching TV. Note the clothes you are wearing in the scene. See yourself get up from the couch, walk over to the refrigerator, and open it. See

yourself reaching in and grabbing a can of soda, then watch yourself close the fridge. See yourself opening the can as you begin to walk back toward the couch. Note the way you are walking and observe the exact instant that you see yourself open the can. Now watch yourself sit back down on the couch and take a sip of the soda.

In this disassociated example you watched the scene play out before your eyes, but you did not feel or sense, in any way, what it was like to go get the soda and drink it. Reserve this perspective for reviewing negative events from the past, climbing or nonclimbing, and for route finding, imagining possible sequences, and risk management. Gather the basic information you need to improve your performance or do the climb, and then engage in associated visualization to preprogram the actual moves for a successful future event.

ASSOCIATED VISUALIZATION

Now let’s reshoot the mental movie of the at-home scene from the associated point of view. This time you will live the scene through your own eyes. Feel the action play out in your imagination just as if you were acting out the scene for real. Again, sit back, relax, and picture this scene playing out in real-life detail.

As you sit on the couch, you laugh at the opening skit of a rerun episode of *The Office*. You decide to go get a soda from the fridge, so you get up and begin walking toward the kitchen. Look around the room at the various pieces of furniture (or pictures on the wall) you pass on your way to the fridge. Enter the kitchen and feel your arm tug the refrigerator door open. Feel the cool air rush out and chill your face. As you reach into the fridge for the soda, notice the colors and design of the can, then sense the cold, damp feel of the can in your hand. Now feel your arm slam the door shut and hear the sound it makes in closing. Conclude the scene by tasting the soda as you gulp it down—what flavors do you taste?

This example reveals the explicit detail you should try to build into your associated visualization. Granted, it will take some practice to develop Steven Spielberg-like detail into your mental movies, but that's the goal. Commit to making a short "film" for all your project routes, and don't hesitate to reshoot or edit the mental movie as you gain new information or beta for the route. Quality mind programming will improve the quality of your real-life performances. Guaranteed!

Uses of Visualization

I hope you now recognize that visualization is an immensely powerful tool that can be used to enhance performance in all aspects of your life. I'm sure you use simple visualization every day, maybe without even knowing it. For example, when you think about the best way to drive across town, I'm sure you see the key turns or landmarks along the way in your mind's eye beforehand. Visualization is also used "effectively" by people who worry a lot—part of their worry ritual is wild visualization of some future event that may or may not happen to them (or some loved one). This type of negative visualization is most painful and depressing when done from an associated perspective. Such negative visualization is pathological, since you are putting yourself through the pain of some future event that may never happen.

Some climbers become consumed in the same types of negative moviemaking of future events. For instance, if you visualize yourself failing on a route or in competition, you not only preprogram this possible outcome but also destroy your self-confidence in the process. To avoid this, it's vital that you visualize only positive events and ideal outcomes when you project into the future in the associated state. Switch to the disassociated mode if you need to visualize things (from a risk management perspective) that might go wrong—say, on an on-sight lead. See from the on-TV view the possible falls you could take and what risks might be involved in the ascent.

Described below are several settings where you can use visualization to improve your safety and mind-set (among other things), as well as the chances of the ideal outcome coming true.

PREPROGRAMMING A REDPOINT ASCENT

Since you've been on the route before, you could begin with disassociated visualization of your last attempt. See yourself climbing the route and note what things need to be corrected or refined for the next attempt. Now use the associated perspective to create a movie, as seen through your own eyes, of the perfect ascent you plan to make. Imagine all the important aspects of doing the route, including the crux moves, gear placements or clips, rest positions, and such. Create the feel of doing the moves as well as the feeling of being relaxed and centered as you move into the crux. Make the movie positive and perfect in every way, and always conclude with the feeling of reaching the top.

PREPARING FOR AN ON-SIGHT ASCENT

Visualization is invaluable when applied to a climb you've never been on before. Since you have no firsthand experience, it will be very hard to create an accurate movie from the associated perspective. Therefore, you'll want to spend most of your time visualizing from a disassociated perspective.

After studying the climb from below, create images or a movie of yourself climbing the route from the on-TV perspective. See yourself dropping in gear at the obvious placements as well as hanging out at what appear to be good rest positions. As described above, you will want to visualize any hazards unique to this climb—where a lead fall might be dangerous, what you can do to minimize the risk, and so forth. Also, if you can see enough detail from the ground, consider creating two movies of possible sequences through the crux. This way, if you get up there and find that one will obviously not work, you can call up the second movie and continue climbing without delay.

You might finish up your visualization by moving into the associated state and trying to imagine what you might feel and see as you climb the sequence you came up with from the disassociated perspective. This is not always possible but would be beneficial.

PREPARING FOR COMPETITION

In competition climbing, good visualization skills might mean the difference between winning and finishing in the middle of the pack. Depending on the competition format, you will want to employ the redpoint and on-sight visualization strategies discussed above. Since many events allow only a brief preview period, you will only be able to create a “rough-cut” movie, including the basic route path, location of the obvious rests, and whatever you can glean about the moves or sequence. Even if you can’t decipher a sequence (or if you didn’t get a route preview), you can still take a mental picture of the wall and project yourself climbing with grace and confidence to the top. Most important, strive to eliminate any self-defeating images that might cross your mind in the hours and minutes leading up to your ascent of the wall.

“CLIMBING” INJURED OR TIRED

If you climb for enough years, you will at some point likely find yourself laid up due to some type of injury. Whether you are out for a few weeks due to a finger injury or out for the season with a more serious problem, you can still keep climbing in your mind’s eye! While this may not sound like much fun, it is an effective way to maintain your knowledge of a sequence on your project route. Vivid, associated visualization has been shown to cause low-level neuromuscular activity that helps enhance motor learning (Feltz 1983) and maintain the feel of performing the skill.

You can also use this effect to your advantage next time you pump out while working a route. Instead of thrashing around on the climb for the

Tips for Enhancing Performance with Visualization

- Use disassociated visualization (observer’s perspective) for route finding, imagining possible sequences, risk management, and to review failed attempts.
- Use associated visualization to mentally climb the route (climber’s perspective). Feel the ascent evolve, including all physical movements and thought processes. The goal is to mentally practice—virtual experience!—all aspects of doing the climb.
- Make associated visualization as bright and detailed as possible. Avoid any negative visualization.
- To get the best results, engage in visualization in a quiet area. Relax and don’t rush through it—your goal is to visualize the complete ascent from bottom to top with no interruptions.

umpteenth time (and risking injury), call it a day and spend the time pumping a few more “mental laps” on the route. This will help solidify your knowledge of the sequence without the extra physical strain and risk of injury.

Creating Laserlike Focus

The ability to narrow and maintain focus is a crucial sports skill, especially in an activity like climbing where elements of danger exert a constant pull diverting the focus from the move at hand. Widely used, but often misunderstood in the context of a climber’s lexicon, focus is a laserlike concentration of mental energy aimed at the most important task at any particular instant. Since every movement in climbing possesses a different most-important task, it’s vital to be able to redirect your focus, in an

instant, to the finger or foot placement most critical at that moment.

Think of focus as a narrowing of your concentration, much like a zoom lens on a camera. At any given moment you must zoom in on the single task most critical to your performance—toeing down on a small pocket, pulling on a manky finger jam, or shifting your center of mass to just the right balance point. Think about anything else and you may fail at this critical task and fall.

The most difficult part of focusing is learning to zoom in and out quickly from a pinpoint focus to a more wide-angle perspective. For example, a quarterback starts a pass play with a broad focus (when in search for an open receiver), but he instantly zooms in on a single player as he delivers the pass. In climbing, you have to do much the same thing—use a broad focus when hanging out looking for the next hold, then zoom in tight as you reach toward the hold and latch on to it. Similarly, you must zoom in tight when high-stepping on a dime edge, locking off and making a long reach, or floating a deadpoint. If you focus on anything else—your gear, your belayer, your pain, or spectators on the ground—you may as well add a ten-pound weight to your back. Poor focus makes hard moves harder, maybe even impossible.

Practicing Focus

Detailed below is a practice drill for developing focus and a preclimbing strategy for gathering focus in preparation to climb. The Singular Focus Drill is best used when you are climbing on top rope and well below your maximum grade. The Pinpointing Your Focus for a Climb exercise can be used before attempting any climb, though it's especially effective when preparing to start up a difficult route.



SINGULAR FOCUS DRILL

The best time to work on your focus is when climbing a route a couple of grades below your

maximum ability. Whether you're at a gym or the crag, on top rope or lead, attempt to climb a whole route by focusing solely on one aspect of movement.

For instance, try to do a route with your complete focus on just hand placements. Find the best way to grab each hold, use the minimum amount of grip strength necessary to hang on, and feel how your purchase changes as you pull on the hold. Place as little focus as is safely possible on other areas such as your feet, balance, belayer, and the like. For now, let these areas take care of themselves—allow your intuitive sense to determine where your feet go and how your balance should shift.

Chances are you'll find this exercise quite difficult. Your thoughts will naturally wander to other tasks or even be directed to distractions on the ground. If this occurs, simply redirect your focus to the predetermined task—in this case the handholds. It is this process of becoming aware of your lost focus and returning it to the critical task that you are after. Sharpened awareness of lost focus is tantamount to gaining control of focus.

Repeat this exercise regularly but change the focus (onto, say, foot placements or weight shifts) each time. Work on increasing the length of time you can maintain a singular focus—this helps build mental endurance. As you become more skilled, convert this singular focus drill into a dynamic focus drill where your focus constantly shifts to the most critical task at any moment. The goal is to be able to shift your focus quickly among the various tasks involved in doing a route, like the flickering beams of a laser light show.

With practice, the process of directing and redirecting focus will become largely subconscious. On the rare occasions when your focus does wander away from the task of climbing, your well-trained mind will instantly recognize this loss and redirect the focus onto the climb. In this way, becoming constantly engaged and automatic on the climb helps in achieving the highly desired flow state.

Enemies of Concentration

The ability to maintain concentration and focus is a principal factor that separates the best from the rest. Peak performers are less likely to be distracted by irrelevant stimuli or to succumb to worry and outcome-oriented thoughts—they exude confidence and possess a remarkable ability to maintain focus and stay on mission despite distractions, criticism, setbacks, fatigue, or current struggles. So in your quest to improve concentration—and enhance performance—it's helpful to understand the enemies of concentration and the common targets of misplaced focus. Following are six common concentration killers and tips for avoiding them.

1. Focusing on mechanics of well-learned skills.

Skills and climbing moves that you possess high competence in (autonomous learning stage) should be turned over to the preconscious mind. Focusing on execution of well-learned movements often results in mechanical, lower-efficiency movement and diverts concentration from other task-relevant targets. Therefore, on all but the most cruxy or tricky moves, you're best to focus on properly engaging the foot- and handholds (and the move sequence) and allow the mechanics of climbing to take care of themselves.

2. Dwelling on internal feelings and sensations of fatigue.

While you must monitor internal conditions by occasionally turning your focus inward, dwelling on such internal feelings will rob external focus and inhibit performance. A common trait of hardman (and -woman) climbers is the ability to dissociate from the fatigue and pain of an exhausting workout or climb. It's a fact that in focusing on the strain and deepening fatigue during a hard climb, you magnify these feelings and open the door to powerful stopping thoughts. Dissociating from such non-injury-producing "good pain" and dismissing phantom stopping thoughts

empowers you to transcend previous limitations and achieve the uncommon.

3. Entertaining nonproductive self-talk.

Vocal and subvocal self-talk is an inherent and almost ever-present feature of our conscious mind; however, the nature and quality of this self-talk is not always in our favor. Negative self-talk is a powerful concentration and performance killer because it directs attention inward to fretful or fearful thoughts. Therefore, it's essential that you direct positive, productive self-talk that helps maintain focus, aids execution, and sustains motivation. Strive to direct positive self-talk in all you do, and it will become a powerful ally in your toughest times.

4. Focusing on the past.

The essence of effective concentration in sport is being fully engaged in the action of the moment. If you look into the rearview mirror and engage in thoughts of past failures or other irrelevant events, it will quickly diminish or derail your performance. So in engaging the vertical extreme, it's essential that you remain in the present and reflect on past experiences only as is briefly necessary in strategic planning and managing risk.

5. Focusing on the future.

Projecting into the future and pondering a possible performance outcome will thwart task-relevant concentration and impede your performance. Worse yet, in entertaining future-oriented thoughts of failure, you generate pressure and anxiety that makes this unwanted outcome more likely! Controlling concentration and climbing your best therefore demands that you detach from outcome-oriented thinking and engage the moment completely.

6. Visual and auditory distractions.

We live in an era of ubiquitous distractions, rampant ADD (attention deficit disorder), and almost unlimited

potential for electronic and social engagement. Possessing a quiet, in-the-moment mental state can be exceedingly difficult to attain and maintain if you allow all this interference to reach your brain. The first step to developing better concentrative skills, then, is to endeavor to systematically eliminate distractions in all aspects of your life. In climbing, strive to eliminate possible distractions before you engage the route, and aspire to become a master

at blocking out distracting people and sounds as you climb. As a final note, I want to stress that your mental state can benefit greatly by eliminating some of the things that hinder concentration in your nonclimbing hours. What electronics can you turn off (or discard), and what other actions could you take to reduce non-task-relevant stimuli and other distractions? The payoff is the gift of improved mental clarity, concentration, and self-awareness.



Kyle O'Meara focused on sticking the crux of Unbirthday (V6) at the Stone Garden, Uinta Mountains, UT.
SAVANNAH CUMMINS



PINPOINTING YOUR FOCUS FOR A CLIMB

This exercise will gather your focus into a single “beam” and quiet your mind as you get ready to cast off up a climb. Perform it after you’ve gone through your preclimb ritual and been put on belay.

Stand at the base of the climb, assume an extended posture (shoulders back), close your eyes, and place the fingertips of your dominant hand against the rock face. Your fingertips should be touching the wall lightly (not gripping a hold), and your hand and arm should be completely relaxed. Now take three deep belly breaths, inhaling through your nose to a count of five and exhaling through your mouth to a count of ten. Let a wave of relaxation wash across your body, and then narrow your focus to the tips of your fingers touching the rock. Concentrate singly on the sensation of your fingertips touching the rock—you should begin to feel the thermal energy moving from your fingers to the rock (on rare occasions when the rock is hotter than your body, you will feel thermal energy conducting into your fingertips). Maintain a relaxed, singular focus on the energy exchange between your fingertips and the rock for anywhere from thirty seconds to a minute or two. If your focus ever wanders, simply redirect it to your fingertips. Soon your mind will become completely still: All your attention is pinpointed on the tips of your fingers. On reaching this state, open your eyes and begin climbing.

Using Preclimb Rituals to Create Focus

Preclimb rituals are a powerful way to narrow your focus in the hours and minutes leading up to an ascent. Like a pilot’s preflight checklist, a climber’s preclimb ritual should consist of every single activity, big or small, that is necessary to ensure a safe, successful journey. For example, my typical preclimb ritual begins with scoping the route to determine the best path and, hopefully, figure out the key moves and rest positions. Next, I perform a few minutes (or more) of mental rehearsal and

visualization as I try to feel the moves and pre-program in the sequence. Upon gaining a sense of comfort and knowledge about the route, I put on my shoes and tie in to the rope. I complete my preclimb ritual by taking a few slow, deep breaths, straightening my posture, and cracking a smile in anticipation of the great fun that awaits me. This entire ritual typically takes between five and fifteen minutes (depending on the difficulty and length of the climb), and it leaves me in an ideal state to make my best effort.

Develop your own unique rituals based on what makes you feel most prepared and psyched for a route. Think back to some of your best past performances to gain some clues as to what to include. What did you think and do in preparing for that climb? What did you eat or drink, how did you warm up, and how long did you rest between

Tips for Creating Focus

1. Train focus by using the Singular Focus Drill (page 49) while lead climbing in the gym or top roping outside.
2. Develop a detailed preclimb ritual that includes warming up, scoping the route, analyzing risk, visualizing the ascent, preparing your gear, putting on your shoes, and tying in to the rope. Use this same ritual before every climb and you will consistently create a high level of focus.
3. Use the Pinpointing Your Focus for a Climb exercise (on this page) as your final task before beginning up the route.
4. Strive for process-oriented thought and avoid dwelling on past outcomes or what’s ahead. Stay in the moment.
5. If you discover that your focus is scattered, simply acknowledge this and redirect your attention to the move or action at hand. Consider using the Pinpointing Your Focus exercise again.

climbs? Awareness of all the factors—little and big—that lead up to your best performances is a key to being able to reproduce similar results in the future.

Experiment with different rituals and analyze what seems to work best. An effective preclimb ritual doesn't need to be extravagant or long. In fact, a short, concise ritual that quickly gets you prepared and focused to climb is best. Upon developing a ritual that works, stick with it!

Mental Wings Strategies to Enhance Problem Solving and Learning

I conclude this chapter with six mental strategies to enhance your skills at problem solving and learning of a difficult sequence or complex route. Being able to quickly decipher perplexing cruxes while conserving mental and physical energy is a master skill. Learn to utilize these skills effectively and you'll be on your way to becoming a grand master at flashing.

I should add that if you find this chapter on mental training to be enlightening and exciting, due to the huge potential this subject holds for breakthroughs in climbing performance, then do check out my book *Maximum Climbing: Mental Training for Peak Performance and Optimal Experience*. This text presents what I believe you will find to be a fascinating, in-depth study of the many facets of mental training, including dozens of powerful mind-training techniques and climbing strategies. Learn more at www.MaximumClimbing.com.

1. Focus on problem solving, not performance.

One thing I love about working a hard boulder problem or project route is the challenge of studying a complex problem and gradually seeing a beautiful, unique sequence take form. Just like piecing together a puzzle when you were a kid, you can best solve a rock puzzle by remaining focused on the task and having fun regardless of how the long the puzzle takes to complete.

For instance, when working a boulder problem or crux sequence, ponder the beauty of the rock puzzle and feel the joy of being engaged in this challenging process. This disposition will shift you out of the must-not-fail mind-set of frustration and help turn your focus away from the problem and onto finding a solution. Remember, the brain naturally magnifies whatever you focus on. Obviously you want to magnify the possible solution, not the problem, so always be solution oriented.

2. Relax and remain positive.

Both problem solving and motor learning occur most rapidly in a stress- and anxiety-free state. Therefore, controlling tension through deep breathing, positive visualization, and remaining process oriented is crucial for accelerating these processes.

It's also fundamental that you eliminate thoughts of needing to flash the route or having to redpoint the climb this attempt—these are both positions that work against you. By entertaining such needs, you create stress and anxiety that may prevent the very thing you desire. Instead, acknowledge that falling is part of the learning process, and accept each fall as providing a clue for success—so don't ignore it! Predetermine that you will accept a fall (and find the clue) if it happens, and believe completely that success will come with creativity, effort, and patience. In doing so, you create the optimal state for learning and succeeding most quickly.

3. Chunk down the route.

Chunking down a long, hard route into a series of short problems makes the climb less overwhelming and easier to learn. Furthermore, these short problems or chunks can each be viewed as a short-term goal to be reached or accomplished. So, while you may fail for several days on the project as a whole, you will experience short-term success as you solve each of the individual chunks. This sense of success helps keep you energized, positive, and on track to eventually succeed on the route.

When working through the individual chunks, avoid becoming obsessed on any one of them. Beating yourself up on, say, the second chunk of a six-chunk route is self-defeating: Even if you eventually solve this chunk, you'll be too mentally and physically wasted to put in meaningful work on the others. Therefore, it's best to move on to working the next chunk upon the onset of frustration or any judgmental self-talk such as I can't do this or I'll never figure this out. If allowed to burrow into your subconscious, such judgments form the basis for reality. You are much better off solving the rest of the route before returning to the problem section.

Long-term achievement of a formidable goal (where short-term failures are inevitable) demands mental agility as well as the ability to trick yourself into persevering in the face of adversity. Breaking a climb into a series of more manageable chunks and setting yourself up for several small wins is a most effective strategy.

4. Engage both sides of the brain.

You may be familiar with the fact that the brain has two hemispheres—the left hemisphere, which presides over logical, practical, language, mathematical, and related matters, and the right hemisphere, which dominates in creative, artistic, intuitive, situational, and imaginary matters. The majority of people are “left-brained,” and even if you aren't, intense situations with lots of information—like climbing—tend to bring the left brain into command. The result is that many climbers leave their right brain on the ground and therefore handicap their problem-solving ability, big time! I can think of countless times I've fallen on routes because I was thinking in a linear fashion and with blinders on that prevented me from finding a key hold, sequence, or rest. (Cut me a break, I'm a scientist, not an artist!)

The right brain is best accessed when you are in a relaxed state (another reason some climbers have a tough time freeing it up). Thus, bringing

it into play requires that you resist the Type A behavior of rushing up to a route and quickly going for the send, and instead get comfortable at the base of the climb, warm up slowly, and make a relaxed study of the climb before tying in to the rope. Some severely left-brained people will need to force themselves to think out of the box. Seeing the big picture and imagining all the possible approaches and sequences on a climb is a habit you may need to foster through your own initiative. Your goal should be a balanced approach to problem solving in which you can think logically and practically as well as intuitively and creatively. Being able to create (on demand) and leverage this state is one of the hallmarks of brilliant climbers such as Lynn Hill and Chris Sharma, who can perform at an exceedingly high level in a wide range of styles and settings.

5. Employ multisensory learning.

Everything we learn comes through one of our five senses, and the more senses we use in learning, the faster and easier it becomes. Climbers tend to use primarily the sense of vision before they leave the ground, and feel once they begin to climb. While the senses of smell and taste can't contribute to performance in this sport, the auditory sense can also be a powerful learning tool (Knudson 1997), particularly when faced with a tricky boulder problem or when working to memorize a difficult sequence. Climbers who give names to key holds and moves and then create verbal beta are using this trick. Remembering an obscure sequence of tiny holds by feel or vision can be enhanced with descriptive verbal beta like high-step to the credit card edge, then deadpoint to the potato chip flake. It may sound funny, but it works.

Multisensory learning is a sign of the intelligent climber, so begin to talk yourself through sequences in addition to visualizing and feeling the moves. By talking the talk, you make it easier to climb the climb!

6. Try something ridiculous.

The biggest block to learning is judgment. Self-talk like *Others use this sequence, so that must be the best way*, or discounting a novel or improbable sequence that flashes into your mind without trying it first, is a form of self-sabotage. It's vital that you don't limit yourself this way—your brain doesn't know what you can or cannot do until you tell it. Don't pre-judge sequences or your capabilities!

The best problem solvers are both creative and uninhibited. They never hesitate to try a novel solution that's entirely different from the known sequence. You can foster these skills by ignoring the obvious solution—the one that's not currently working for you—and attempting a few completely different, even ridiculous sequences.

Regardless of how improbable a given technique looks—heel hook, undercling, high step, knee bar—don't pass judgment on it until you make a

few attempts with that technique. Try a variety of body positions, foot flags, and lunges, and don't ignore less positive holds like Gastons, side pulls, and pinches. Eliminate the seemingly must-use hold—or at least try using it with the opposite hand. Search for unchalked holds that might unlock the sequence, and keep a constant watch for footholds that are off the main line of the route—a single missed foothold or high step can make the difference between “impossible” and “possible.”

A common thread running through this chapter is that the mental and technical aspects of climbing are intimately connected. Ahead in chapter 4 you will find an in-depth study of motor learning and performance (how you acquire skill), as well as a primer on the fundamental climbing techniques and several powerful strategies for developing superior technique. Let's climb onward.

Problem-Solving Tips and Success Strategies

1. Focus on problem solving, not performance. View each climb as a puzzle that you will enjoy and learn from, no matter what the outcome.
2. Relax and remain confident. Use the ANSWER Sequence to maintain a relaxed state, and direct positive, productive self-talk to fortify confidence and sustain effective action in the face of difficult climbing.
3. Chunk down the route into manageable sections. Work the most difficult chunks first, then begin linking the sections from the top down.
4. Engage both sides of the brain. Which side is more dominant for you? Strive to bring both creative, intuitive (right brain) and analytical, practical (left brain) power to work for you.
5. Employ multisensory learning by seeing, feeling, and talking yourself through tough sequences.
6. When all else fails, try something ridiculous! Seemingly impossible cruxes often require a trick move or non-intuitive sequence, so experiment with a variety of moves and techniques, no matter how improbable or inappropriate they seem to be.



*Steph Davis cruising up
Hidden Treasure (5.13),
Moab, Utah.* CHRIS NOBLE